



UNREAL ESTATE:
(Left) The Munnar office of CPI(M) doubles up as hotel; party HQ in Thiruvananthapuram

public deposits running into crores of rupees with the promise of doubling the money in violation of the RBI rules. Allegedly, Venugopal failed to keep his promise after taking the money, prompting the company owners to file a complaint to the party local committee. Though the CPI(M) claims that Venugopal is the only accused in the case, there are charges that the Government has derailed the investigation, started when UDF was in power.

For a party that prides itself on its working class ethics, the CPI(M) has been going through a rough patch in recent times. The last two months have been particularly embarrassing for the party which is now seen as among the biggest violators in the large-scale land encroachment in Munnar. Last week, fresh revelations revealed that the CPI(M) had been running a multi-storey budget hotel on the upper floors of its party office constructed on the encroached land in Munnar. This considerably slowed the much trumpeted demolition drive at the behest of Chief Minister V.S. Achuthanandan, even forcing him to publicly declare that party offices and religious institutions



Many believe that the corruption scandal is the latest chapter in the fight between Vijayan and the chief minister.

would be spared from the ongoing demolition drive. The Government later withdrew the order when the high court rapped it on the knuckles and termed it "unlawful". "The CPI(M) is the largest land encroacher in the state. Even A.K.G. Centre, its state headquarters, stands on encroached land," said V.D. Satheesan, a Congress MLA. According to him, the CPI(M) has launched several unauthorised constructions worth hundreds of crore on encroached lands in various parts of the state. "The party should close down its political office and get into the real estate business," says the legislator.

There are those who believe that this incident is only the latest chapter in the unending war between the two factions of the state CPI(M), one led by the powerful, but far from popular, state secretary, Pinarayi Vijayan and the other that owes allegiance to the less dominant but hugely popular chief minister. Venugopal, like many of the other Marxists caught with their fingers in the till, is a Vijayan confidant. It was the opposite faction, rather than the Opposition, that first raked up the issue and demanded action against Venugopal. The state secretariat had sat over the matter and decided to act only when the local committee threatened to refer it to the central committee. The fight between the two state heavyweights has already resulted in the suspension of the chief minister and state secretary from attending the Politburo meetings.

Though party leaders in New Delhi are keen to work out a truce, the rift is only likely to widen with the preliminary state level meetings all set to begin in September, ahead of the state conference which traditionally precedes the All India Party Congress to be held in March at Coimbatore next year. Having learnt his lessons in Marxism from Achuthanandan, who is nearly 20 years older, Vijayan later turned against his mentor and the two have never seen eye to eye since. At the last state conference in 2005, the Vijayan faction had decimated its inner party rivals. Achuthanandan, of course, was not the chief minister then and thus, may have been handicapped. Today, with power in his hands, the 82-year-old is not going to let his age come in the way of giving his opponents a bloody nose. ■